

Game Research Survey

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In 2002, Head Designer of the trading card game *Magic: The Gathering* (MTG), Mark Rosewater, published an article that discussed the profiles of three types of Magic players identified by their research teams and used by their design teams when creating MTG: Johnny, who plays to express his creativity, Timmy, who plays socially and enjoys “big”, fun plays, and Spike, who plays competitively and wants to win. [1] Later in 2015, Rosewater added two more profiles: Vorthos, who is interested in the lore, storytelling, and art of the game, and Melvin, who is interested in the mechanics and rules of the game. [2] The articles from the Head Designer of MTG illustrate an important concept in game design: not only do people play different games according to their preferences, but they will play the same game for different reasons. This tension is not unknown to the game design research community at large:

“...theorists have engaged in debate about whether videogames should be considered as stories or as rule-based systems of play – perspectives often referred to as “narratology” and “ludology,” respectively...”[3]

Rather than discussing the details of this partial taxonomy of games, I am interested in how the ludic structure of a game can facilitate the narrative of the game. In film and television, which are certainly narratively-focused entertainment mediums, the “suspension of disbelief” is often the focus of discourse online. An example is the popular meme that is merely a screenshot with actual lines from *The Two Towers* film from the Lord Of The Rings Trilogy:



Fig. 1. orc menu meme

Commenters will usually ask “How do orcs know what a menu is? Have they seen a restaurant?” The answer given by Tolkien nerds is that *The Lord Of The Rings* is an English translation of the hobbit-written Red Book of Westmarch and hobbits are certainly familiar with the concepts of restaurants and menus.[4] Answers such as these lead to humorous revisions such as the response shown in Figure 2. (What are memes for, after all?)

Despite video games not being pure narrative mediums like film or television, they are also subject to this kind of



Fig. 2. orc menu meme response

discourse, sometimes very tense when they become American culture-war adjacent. A *Vice* article reported that the Battlefield sub-reddit had to ban complaints about “historical accuracy” after the release of *Battlefield V* [5]. Tocci writes

“When rules and fiction conflict with one another, rather than complementing one another, it is usually the fiction that suffers, becoming *incoherent*...story-oriented games have come to more closely resemble movies, and not just for brief cut scenes. Given that narrative potential has been dismissed by some theorists, it is worth asking what players are getting from these experiences, and how different conceptualizations of videogames inform or impede with their design.” [3]

One particular incoherency that I was interested when I was thinking about making my game *Fleet* is the death of the player-character. When you play *StarFox64* and die, your ship crashes and explodes while your teammates shout in horror or disbelief. Then you reset and are playing the level again, minus your handy laser upgrades. From a strictly narrative approach, this could take the player out of the fantasy of being a starfighter pilot. I have never experienced this cognitive dissonance personally while playing, but my reasons for playing a game are not universal. This has certainly bothered some people and they’ve made games about it. *You Only Live Once* and *One Chance* are examples of games meant to prevent you from playing again after you die. (This is different from games like *Outer Wilds* that are “spoiled” in some sense after you play them and a twist is revealed, like a murder mystery.) As Tocci points out

“Some audiences do indeed care about not just progressing through challenges, but progressing through a story. This engagement with story can be broken by fictional incoherence – previously theorized as unproblematic in games – including failure and frustrating repetition. This may be more important to some players than to others, and is certainly more of an issue for games designed to emphasize story, but it should be evident that it is no longer safe to assume that the desire to master challenges is necessarily the primary or sole appeal of contem-

porary videogames...the rules and fiction of games can conflict to create an incoherent (or downright frustrating) experience for players. Careful consideration and attempts to balance rules and fiction can help to correct this. Nevertheless, death and failure offer particularly problematic scenarios: In the absence of death as a penalty, how can one preserve fictional coherence but also make the player feel that something is really at stake, that failure is really worthy of avoidance, suspense, even dread?"

Alex Mitchell writes

"In repeat plays of interactive stories or story-focused games, players tend to expect to experience something different from their original experience... At the same time, the expectation generally is that one play session will be self-contained, in the sense that there are no explicit, diegetic references to other, earlier play sessions. For example, players generally do not expect characters to refer to events that took place in previous play sessions unless the current session is clearly a continuation of the previous session. Similarly, while players are used to certain gameplay elements only becoming available in the current play session as the result of actions they took in previous play sessions, they generally do not expect the "unlocking" of these elements to be justified, or even referred to, within the storyworld." [6]

Frank Boseman examined player death as it relates to the narrative of the game.

"Ludologically, the death of the game's protagonist (also known as player's death or avatar death) is one of the most prominent feedback systems of almost all digital games...Some games...try to provide a narratologically credible embedding for the death of the avatar within the logic of their fictional world and lore (death narrative), but the majority of games simply refrain from any such embedding" [7]

So: how to resolve this inconsistency using the design of the game itself? Well, they are playing a game and not just watching a movie, so the act of playing the game should be the solution!

"Player agency is central to interactive narrative and games." [8]

writes Carstensdottir in *Naked and on Fire*. The Tocci paper lists various ways that games have handled this issue, but the one I find most interesting is "Diegetic Explanations for Rebirth" [3]. That is, explanations for the repetition from within the story itself that do not take the player out of the narrative. Tocci describes a particular mechanic for this in 2003's remake *Prince of Persia: Sands of Time*:

"Sometimes, however, the protagonist cannot escape death: Even the Prince of Persia runs out of mystical sand eventually. When this happens, the narrator, in a move reminiscent of 1001 Arabian Nights, speaks over the "Continue" screen, "No, no, that's not what happened." The player may need to repeat certain

scenes, but this move likely signals an attempt to preserve some sense of fictional coherence." [3]

Prince of Persia is also referenced in the paper *Temporal Agency and Timeplay in Video Games* [9], which presents a way in which ludic and narrative perspectives of games are related.

"Temporal agency in video games refers to the player's ability to control and manipulate time within the game world to shape their experiences and outcomes...Exploring temporal agency as the subset of ludic agency offers new insights into how players engage with and shape their experiences in video games." [9]

The *Naked and on Fire* paper also gives evidence that the ludic aspects of a game and the narrative aspects are intertwined:

"In other words, structure, choices, and endings, as the navigable shape, the means of progression, and the ultimate destination, respectively, are the manifestation of narrative impact within a game's design." [8]

The *Temporal* paper [9] identifies four ways in which games give players temporal agency: Adaptive Timeplay (rewind, replicate, and refine gameplay), Strategic Timeplay (a tool for planning and optimizing), Ethical Timeplay (exploration of moral consequences across attempts), and Reflective Timeplay (engagement with questions about free will and determinism). [9] All four can be used to integrate a death and reset cycle into the narrative. But, as Cassandra Barkman notes

"Every game with a save/load feature already contains time loops. Acknowledging them within the gameworld essentially narrativizes elements like repetition and failure that are frequently part of play but outside of a game's storyworld." [10]

But this is not an integration into the narrative structure! However, consider the roguelite/roguelike genres that have come to dominate the recent indie game world and are examples of integrating death into the gameplay experience. By providing an in-universe explanation that allows continued play after death and in fact in some ways rewards the death, I think that rogue-like/lite games further the exploration of the intersection between ludic and narrative perspectives for game design would be an interesting direction to go in. Using the narrative of the game itself to explain the respawn is used in a very popular recent roguelike, *Hades*, which is examined in *Rescripting of the Genre Through Greek Mythology in Hades* by Jaswanth Arithimalla [11]. The game uses the underworld myth of Hades itself. If you are already dead and you die, where do you go but where you already are? Within *Fleet*, my intention with the replacement pilot mechanic was to provide a narrative explanation for a ludic necessity: what to do when your ship explodes but you want to keep playing?

Whether these approaches affect player enjoyment of the game probably depends on whether they are a Johnny, Timmy, Spike, Vorthos, or Melvin and we try to build different games for each of them. Pity poor Mark Rosewater, who is trying to build one.

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